

APPLE OF MY EARTH (WT)

Written by

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This fable is told from one constant, never-changing perspective; a close-on, fixed frame, centering a unique protagonist: the potato plant. Throughout this filmic tale, it will always remain in the foreground and at the center of our view. Even if it is charred to a crisp, ripped out of the ground or trampled into inexistence; our gaze remains mounted to its undeniable, timeless presence.

ACT 1

EXT. ANDEAN VALLEY - DAY

We FADE IN FROM BLACK to reveal a vast landscape in high altitude, layered with countless mountain slopes stretching to the horizon.

Amidst the farthest ridge of towering peaks rests SABANCAYA, a mythic, perfectly shaped volcanic presence. A thin plume of smoke rises from it to a vast, blue sky.

Humanity has yet to interfere with this sacred place. But the vegetation, lush and rich in spite of the high altitude, *is inviting.*

In the foreground of our view lies an untouched patch of grass-covered soil. There, our unlikely hero emerges: a POTATO SPROUT courageously pushes through the ground.

Within seconds -- and by defying all laws of time -- the seedling grows into a stubborn, leaf-bushy plant.

Then, as the sun embraces it with warm light, the plant shows gratitude by developing a beautiful, white flower.

Another blossom follows suit. And another. More buds BURST open to unveil their inner beauty.

The blooms attract a curious BEE, hovering into frame, inspecting them, then choosing one by one to drink nectar from.

As the sun begins to set, the nurtured bee moves on; its flight slightly slower, heavy from the flora feast.

The flowers fade, the plant's leaves thicken. The soil around the plant begins to slightly swell.

A beat.

Night falls and a bright moon rises, shedding cold light on the valley and our plant.

We linger in the rich, nightly SOUNDSCAPE of this untouched land, when we begin to hear SOUNDS of toe-nailed paws approaching.

And after a moment, four sure-footed, slender legs enter the frame, slowly approaching the potato plant. The animal stops to boom its head into frame to smell it with hungry curiosity. A LLAMA!

SUDDENLY. The Llama's head instinctively shoots up and out of our view; as if sensing approaching danger. Faint SOUNDS of stone CLICKS and RUSTLING of grass.

The Llama's legs exude a slight tremble.

Then they SPRINT OFF, stirring the air around our potato plant's leaves.

The SOUNDS of the animal's flight dissipate into the night, leaving an eerie silence to herald a dangerous presence closing in.

A deep, hungry PURR emerges. This is no mere cat. The sounds are much deeper. Deadlier.

With skillful, predatory pads, the legs of a PUMA stalk by; merely brushing the plant with its flank as it trails its prey.

The hunter only passes by and pays no attention to our plant; stalking off into the direction in which the Llama took off.

The deep PURR fades away and the night falls quiet again.

Beat.

Then: the SOUNDS of toe-nailed paws approach *yet again*. This time more careful; almost inaudible; the sneaky, courageous Llama returns!

Its head peeks back into frame as it resumes sniffing the potato plant.

Driven by hunger and forgetful of the dangers abound, it begins to loosen the ground with its paws.

As it skillfully digs deeper around the potato plant, we get the slightest glimpse of what treasure hides beneath the soil:

PAPAS, bathed in moonlight.

Potatoes. Much smaller and more rugged than those of our time; still, these earthy nuggets radiate pure energy.

The llama begins to MUNCH on them. And for a peaceful moment, we observe.

Suddenly, with a FIERCE ROAR, the puma leaps into frame out of nowhere, attacking its prey with its deadly claws. The Llama barely manages to escape, and dashes out of frame.

The puma CHASES right after it. And while our gaze remains fixed on the plant -- its roots unearthed, its treasure exposed -- we hear the chilling SOUNDS of a Llama being MAULED TO DEATH in the distance.

A long beat.

A new day breaks, the sun washes away the violent night. And it's witness, our bruised potato, plant gets an unlikely visitor yet again:

This time, we hear the HUMMING of a WOMAN approaching. And without seeing her presence in full, as she enters frame, we see her body parts clothed in colorful, woven garment made from llama fiber.

We do not get a glimpse of her face, as her rugged, deep brown-skinned hands hesitantly dive into frame, down to the papas to inspect the earthy treasure.

Then with a decisive pull, they grab the plant by its lower stems and rip it from the ground along with the potatoes dangling from it.

We now only observe the legs again, as the Woman inspects her harvest; before she resumes her journey and leaves frame.

Her HUMMING SONG dissipates.

Day turns to night and we get to see a small bonfire ignite on one of the many mountain slopes layering the valley in the background.

As the speed of time ramps up, the fire extinguishes and days and nights spiral into a temporal dance, Sabancaya's previously thick plumes of smoke grow thicker and darker.

And as sun and moon, rain and dry weather are chasing each other at eclectic speeds, in the far and blurred distance, HUMANS begin to carve agricultural terraces into the mountain slopes.

The excavated patch of land before us becomes a terrace as well. There a new potato plant grows at the very same spot like the plant before it.

Once the valley's transformation by human hand is completed, time begins to slow and comes to rest on one, gloomy, fateful day.

Dark, thick molasses-like plumes of smoke escape from Sabancaya's peak. Tremors SHAKE the ground; violently wiggling the leaves of our plant.

Deep, heavy SOUNDS of volcanic activity herald a looming catastrophe.

Then -- as if the air is drawn out of the valley by invisible lungs with one breath: Sudden SILENCE.

A beat.

Suddenly, massive vertical eruptions EXPLODE from Sabancaya. A giant pillar of gas and ash pushes upward; within it, deadly, volcanic lightning flickers.

A pyroclastic wave races towards us; a voluptuous surge of darkness and death incinerating everything it touches.

Seconds later, everything turns to utter darkness.

A *long* beat.

A few sun rays pierce the thick fumes; the air clears slowly. Only to reveal the charred remains of the valley.

Then: The crumbly SOUND of something small but unyielding pushing through dark ash and cindered ground:

A green potato SEEDLING pushes through the crusted earth!

Time stops and allows us to marvel at this beautiful bright green miracle.

When suddenly, the stacked mountain slopes and ridges behind it SWOOSH with ROARING SOUNDS to the side like layered flats of a puppeteer theatre being swapped for a new scene.

ACT 2

EXT. ALPINE VALLEY - DAY

As if exchanged by the hands of some capricious god, the tectonic layers of the land are exchanged with those of a valley nestled at the feet of the majestic Alps.

The soil along with the previously emerged seedling MORPHS from the wild Andean patch of land to a carefully maintained field, meticulously structured into ridges and furrows.

We are indeed traveling to a new region of the world; and a different time, too!

Yet this time around, the potato plant seedling at the center of our view is surrounded by many others of its kind, growing next to each other; neatly aligned, along the ridges of the field.

Behind the field, farmhouses are nestled along the shore of a modest, slow-moving river, meandering across the valley. More houses are nestled against the mountain slopes at higher altitude than those on the valley floor.

Once again, defying the laws of time, the sprout grows before our eyes into a full-sized potato plant, while the others follow suit.

The plants produce beautiful flowers, then they fade, the plant's leaves thicken. The soil around the plants begins to slightly swell.

Beat.

Evening falls. The houses' windows illuminate from dim, flickering electric light. We hear muffled laughter of what must be a joyous family occasion (a birthday?) seeping through the walls of one of the closer houses.

Meanwhile the river, tame and gentle, reflects a full moon.

As we transition to a new day, we hear HOOFBEATS approach, paired with the clunky RATTLE of metal machinery.

Then, the muscular legs of a WORK HORSE trot by from left to right across frame, followed by a pulled harness with metal blades cutting across the ridges.

The potato plants are unearthed and from underneath, well-formed potatoes are exposed.

And meanwhile the RATTLING fades into the SOUNDS of subdued CHATTER of a FARMER FAMILY drawing closer.

As they reach our field of vision, the hands and legs of a FARMER and his WIFE dip into frame, removing the potatoes from the soil, and throwing them into carried baskets.

Then, the inevitable happens: Time accelerates yet again, ending the day in mere seconds, with the farmers and their machinery racing across the field, right to left and vice versa; gleaning the field into the distance.

The accelerated succession of days and nights; sun and rain -- we are now familiar with these time ramps -- ignites yet again until another full field of potato plant seedlings has grown.

As the harvest nears, time decelerates and falls still on one fateful day:

A military truck in complete disregard of the fragile sprouts, CRUNCHES its tires across the frame, halting abruptly at its edge.

The legs of a SOLDIER jump out of the vehicle and into frame. A stake is RAMMED into the ground, stride by stride, with what must be a heavy hammer; deeper and deeper until a red and yellow striped sign dips into our view:

"DAMMBAU - EVAKUIERUNGSZONE"

(Dam Construction - Evacuation Zone)

The truck drives off only to reappear in the further background near one of the houses. Along side with it, many more military trucks pull up to the rest of the village in what must be an orchestrated operation.

And while our gaze remains fixed on the potato plant; indifferent and unmoved, we hear DOOR KNOCKS; then, INDISTINCT YELLING, the CRYING OF A BABY; doors being SLAMMED.

We only see them as small and blurry figures, but we can make out FAMILIES being escorted out of their houses and into the trucks by SOLDIERS.

Then, some of the vehicles violently drive off while other trucks stay.

The day turns to night. Our potato plants stands unattended amongst its peers, when the rest of the military trucks finally drive off.

The night is now mute; gone is the muffled laughter and an eerie silence takes hold.

When the sun rises and begins to illuminate the valley, we begin to hear the ROARING motors of 1930s era military aircraft approach from our rear.

Once their volume peaks, two Fokker C-V-E bombers DASH OVER us across the sky towards the houses.

As their low and aggressive flight - at times no more than 30 meters above ground - continues, they circle back around, now FACING and FLYING TOWARDS US. Their mission culminates in the release of heavy, bomb-like looking objects that fall towards the houses.

One bomb hits its target, and demolishes a house in a massive explosion. The other bomb slightly misses by a few meters, yet still destroys a vast majority of its target's structure.

More planes follow - at least 4! - and in a meticulously orchestrated attack sequence, the rest of the houses are destroyed as well.

Finally, the planes fly off, their intimidating SOUNDS dissipating, leaving behind only smoldering remains of what was once a village.

Beat.

As time picks up speed yet again. The field harboring the potato plant, now unattended, becomes over-grown with weeds, some reaching the height of that ominous warning sign.

Yet, as we now race through the days and nights ahead, the SOUNDSCAPE of a massive construction site off screen emerges; gaining in complexity and volume until a rapid stop signals its completion.

The speed of the timelapse decreases, collapsing into one fateful, cloudy day. Without rain, the once peaceful river begins slowly to swell and overflow.

Slowly but surely, the water reaches the destroyed houses, and then moments later our potato plant; engulfing and ultimately swallowing the entire valley floor.

An artificial lake forms in front of our eyes!

As the water begins to climb up on our camera lens, the valley continues to flood until our view angle is completely submerged.

Daylight fades away, as the forming lake becomes deeper and deeper.

MOMENTS LATER we only see a fading silhouette of our potato plant; drowning, slowly decaying and eventually disappearing.

And then it happens again. That celestial interference, where some invisible creator rips apart time and space (as have observed before at the end of Act 1):

As if a gigantic fish tank suddenly BURST in front of our eyes, the massive body of water in front of our eyes washes away to the sides, only to reveal...

ACT 3

INT. AGRICULTURAL CHAMBER - DAY

...a hangar-like facility, with thick-glassed, hexagon-shaped windows offering a spectacular view:

Reddish deserts stretch into the far distance, forming the backdrop to what can only be described as futuristic buildings of a SPACE COLONY located on MARS.

In the foreground of our unchanged point of view, there is yet again that very patch of soil; this time encased in what must be a highly advanced growing pod. More of these pods are lined up in the middle ground of our frame.

A MAN with a thinned-out physique walks into frame – again, we only see the parts of his body exposed to our viewpoint – and dips his rubber-gloved hands into the pod to plant what appears to be a sliced-up potato.

Once finished, his slightly trembling, soiled hands retreat.

The Man leaves frame again.

With an electric BUZZ, powerful ceiling heat lamps cast warm cones of light onto the soil pods.

Then, a sprinkler system -- similar to what we know from our time -- activates, spraying what must be a precisely calculated amount of water onto the soil.

The two systems alternate with mechanical precision: once one switches on, the other switches off.

Outside the agricultural chamber, beyond the thick window glass, a cosmic version of the dance between day and night – now very familiar to us – begins once more.

And at the very center of our view, in that patch of soil, the same miracle occurs, which we have now observed multiple times:

Curious SEEDLINGS of potato plants push through the soil; one of them assuming the exact same centered position within our frame, just like its ancestors in the previous acts.

In the other pods lined up further back, a variety of plants grow too -- most likely vegetables and fruit -- hard to identify from the distance.

While we observe the intervals of heat lamp and artificial rain accelerating faster and faster, the plants grow into their destined size.

Meanwhile and beyond the windows, we see that the colony infrastructure available to our view is not exactly thriving. To the contrary: it is but *decaying*.

The hulls of the buildings are visibly decaying from the harsh conditions, their once-white surfaces dulled by relentless corrosion and reddish dust.

No one seems to be repairing them. No one appears to be restoring their functionality.

During the nights, fewer and fewer lights switch on outside.

The heat lamp BUZZES, flickers, struggling to turn on.

The potato plant responds to the warm embrace of artificial light by producing one singular bud, which then surely POPS open to reveal a beautiful white flower.

Then another bud develops. And another. And another. The plant at the center of our view goes into full bloom.

The rest of the vegetation follows suit.

Then, a small DRONE -- similar in size to a bee -- WHIZZES into frame.

It hovers in front of one of the potato flowers, scans it.

It begins to fly from bloom to bloom, pollinating them one by one.

The drone completes its task, then whizzes out of frame, only to reenter further back to pollinate the other vegetation further back.

Beat.

As the chamber continues its rhythm, the flowers fade. Leaves thicken. The soil around the plant begins to swell. The plants further back develop colorful fruit and vegetables.

The Man with the gloves returns to harvest; and while we only get to see his lower body and hands, we notice that one of his gloves is repaired with a piece of silver tape.

He grabs our plant by the stem, rips it out along with its tubers and walks off.

Time accelerates again. And in a timelapse, as days and nights continue to whiz by, the fruits and vegetables in the back are depleted steadily.

Outside the thick glass, the colony continues its decay.

Until one night – as time slows down yet again – no lights ignite at all. Only those in our chamber remain.

The Man with rubber gloves returns; again only partially available to our point of view.

His body appears even thinner now. His movements slower. His rubber gloves show wear and tear, the patch of silver tape must have fallen off.

Then, a deep, dull RUMBLE shakes the chamber. Oblivious to it, the Man does not physically react.

Outside, the Martian horizon begins to disappear, as a wall of red dust gathers in the distance, spreading across the desert like an enormous, approaching tide.

The chamber lights flicker.

The Man presses one quarter of the potato into the soil -- now restored and plantless -- where our plant stood; the others next to it.

He walks off, slowly, weakened and hampered by a painful limp.

The heat lamp BUZZES overhead. The sprinkler system activates.

Yet only a few tired drops fall.

Beat.

The red storm reaches the colony.

Dust SLAMS against the thick hexagonal windows, blotting our view to the outside.

The chamber begins to tremble again; this time stronger.

A warning light at the backside of the chamber begins to pulse, it is accompanied by a bone-chilling ALERT TONE.

The sandstorm grows LOUDER, filling the chamber with a deep, grinding ROAR.

The glass strains. We hear CRACKS, SOUNDS of metal frames bending.

Somewhere off-screen, a seal breaks with a BANG.

A thin HISS cuts through the noise.

The glass of the Chamber now visibly CRACKS.

A sharp line splits across the transparent shell, racing from one edge to the next.

The heat lamp flickers violently, then extinguishes.

BAM. The window glass BURSTS. Martian dust explodes into the chamber.

The remaining vegetation is swallowed by red darkness, bending under the violent pressure.

The soil lifts from the pod, scattering into the air.

Then, like a submarine imploding under too much pressure, the chamber collapses in a violent instant.

Darkness.

A long beat.

Only the BLOWING SOUNDS of the sand storm remains.

We FADE IN to dust settling on shredded debris of the chamber, covered in red dust.

As the wind lifts away some of the dust one bruised piece of potato, is revealed.

The dust covers it.

Cut to black.

THE END.